
Chapter 5 — Group 5

RELATIONSHIP DECISIONS

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions before coming to group. *You will not share what you wrote in this chapter in group, but you should participate in others' discussions.* Your group facilitator will meet with you individually and review this chapter.]

In many tangled relationships, the persons involved are doing things for others that they should be doing for themselves. Recall the story about the young man who was bailed out of jail by his parents. His parents got him jobs. They drove him to work. They cleaned up his room and cleaned his clothes. They regularly gave him money. They took him to counselors and put him in programs. They defended his behavior to others. They fed him. And on and on it goes. What we haven't told you is that this "young man" was nearly 30 years old then! His parents resented him for rejecting their help. He resented his parents forcing "help" on him.

But when he was jailed, the man immediately called his parents to bail him out. He was 'dependent' on them. When they bailed him out, he got into an argument with them because they were always trying to "tell him what to do." Then he ran away leaving behind the real possibility of his parents losing their home because of it.

This man's parents often felt embarrassed by their son. They sometimes said that he was making them crazy. To some extent, their self-esteem, their feelings of self-worth as parents, were dependent on his behavior. Yet, his behavior was definitely out of their control and, at some level of awareness, *they knew it*. But they still believed and hoped that they might be able to change him. They believed they could control him.

All of the fundamental issues of codependency are present in this real-life example. In this chapter, we'd like you to examine *at least one and no more than three* of your problem relationships. You'll be asked if you want to make changes and then make a brief plan. Remember that this is **not** shared in group.

1. Identifying The Problem Relationships

In the numbered spaces below, list the identity (name, nickname) of at least one, and no more than three, people that you believe are *problem relationships* for you. Write exactly what the nature of this relationship is after their name. (Ex: My husband/wife; My father; My boyfriend.) Then answer the question: *Is this a codependent relationship?* (yes or no)

Relationship 1: _____ What is the relationship?: _____

Is this a codependent relationship? _____

Relationship 2: _____ What is the relationship?: _____

Is this a codependent relationship? _____

Relationship 3: _____ What is the relationship?: _____

Is this a codependent relationship? _____

2. What Are You Trying To Control?

In the spaces that follow, list whether you have been trying to control the behavior of the people you identified as problem relationships. (yes or no) Then write exactly what you have been trying to control. (Examples: drug use, crime, violence, anger, work behavior, love life.) Finally, answer this: do you believe you can control this behavior. (yes or no)

1. Have you been trying to control some of this person's behavior? _____
What behavior? _____
Do you still believe you can control it? _____
2. Have you been trying to control some of this person's behavior? _____
What behavior? _____
Do you still believe you can control it? _____
3. Have you been trying to control some of this person's behavior? _____
What behavior? _____
Do you still believe you can control it? _____

3. What Are Your Unhealthy Behaviors?

In the spaces below, try to identify **your unhealthy behaviors** that have occurred because of this relationship. (Examples: I've lied for him; I make excuses.) Then answer the following questions.

1. Your unhealthy behaviors in this relationship: _____
Do you want to change this behavior? _____
How will you do it? _____
When will you start? (Date) _____
2. Your unhealthy behaviors in this relationship: _____
Do you want to change this behavior? _____
How will you do it? _____
When will you start? (Date) _____
3. Your unhealthy behaviors in this relationship: _____
Do you want to change this behavior? _____
How will you do it? _____
When will you start? (Date) _____

4. Is Your Self-Worth Related To These Relationships?

In the spaces below, decide if how you feel about yourself — your self-worth — has suffered because of this relationship. (yes or no) Then answer: “How has your self-worth suffered? What can you do to repair this damage?”

1. Has your self-worth suffered in this relationship? _____

How has your self-worth suffered? _____

How can you repair this damage? _____

When will you start? (Date) _____

2. Has your self-worth suffered in this relationship? _____

How has your self-worth suffered? _____

How can you repair this damage? _____

When will you start? (Date) _____

3. Has your self-worth suffered in this relationship? _____

How has your self-worth suffered? _____

How can you repair this damage? _____

When will you start? (Date) _____

If you have filled out this chapter before group and adequately discussed them with your facilitator, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.